their presence. It was in that context that senior BJP leader Lal Krishna Advani has written in his autobiography, *My Country, My Life* (Rupa & Co, 2008), that the BJP's agitation against Sikh extremism influenced Indira Gandhi's decision to order troops into the Golden Temple in 1984. [7]

Though Atal Bihari Vajpayee's minority government remained in power from 1998 to 2004, it could not do much to address issues related to Punjab and the 1984 pogrom as a result of its coalition compulsions and the sensitivities of its Hindu vote-bank in the north, which had still not fully recovered from the lingering poisonous effects of the policy of the Hindu-Sikh divide.

The BJP's victory in the 2014 general elections appeared to have changed the situation. It came to power for the first time with a majority of its own (282 out of a total of 543 seats) in the House and improved its performance (303) in the 2019 elections. Also, its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners have no interest in defending the Congress's role in Punjab or 1984 pogrom.

As mentioned in the Preface, signs of change, especially since 2017, were the main reason I felt encouraged to write this book. Certain actions taken by the NDA government during the year-long celebrations of the 550th birth anniversary (on 12 November 2019) of Guru Nanak, and also the convictions of some well-known criminals linked to the 1984 pogrom, appeared to have created a favourable impression of the present government on the Sikhs of Punjab and some of those living abroad.

Decisions taken by this government related to Guru Nanak's birth anniversary celebrations included removing in September 2019 the names of 312 of the remaining 314 Sikh NRIs from the black list that barred them from travelling to India; sanction of Rs 175 crore to Guru Nanak Dev University in Amritsar for establishment of the Centre for Inter-faith Studies; development of Sultanpur Lodhi, a town associated with the life of Guru Nanak, as a heritage city; opening of the Kartarpur corridor from the Indian side; and display of the Sikh religious symbol *Ek Onkar* (there is only one God) on Air India aircraft. [8]

The speeding up of investigations and proper prosecution in some of the 1984 pogrom-related cases has resulted in the